



FIRST HOME BUYER GUIDE — AOTEAROA NEW ZEALAND

Buying your first home. Let's get you there.

A practical step-by-step guide for Kiwis getting onto the property ladder — from your first KiwiSaver question to the day you collect the keys.

WHAT'S INSIDE

Contents.

Ten short sections covering everything you need to know before talking to a lender — without the jargon.

01	Why buy your first home now?	03
02	The Three P's: Prepare, Pre-approve, Purchase	04
03	Getting deposit-ready faster	05
04	The first home buyer journey, step by step	06
05	Costs and support explained	07
06	Real-life examples from Kiwi first home buyers	08
07	Adviser versus going direct to a bank	09
08	Five signs you're ready to start the conversation	09
09	Frequently asked questions	10
10	Next steps and how to reach me	11

01 — WHY THIS GUIDE?

Buying your first home in New Zealand can feel overwhelming.

KiwiSaver. Pre-approval. LVR. The First Home Loan. Conditional offers. Every conversation seems to introduce three new terms before you've understood the last one.



The good news is that most first home buyers don't need to become experts. You need a clear path, someone in your corner who knows the lender rules, and honest answers when you ask "is this actually achievable for us?"

This guide walks you through the path. The Three P's framework. How to get deposit-ready faster. What support is actually available. What the journey looks like from the first chat to the day you collect the keys.

I'm JJ. I've helped hundreds of Kiwis through this process. **I work for you, not the banks.** The advice is free, and the conversation might save you years.

02 — THE FRAMEWORK

The Three P's: Prepare, Pre-approve, Purchase.

Most first home buyers try to do everything at once, then get stuck. The Three P's break the journey into three clear stages so you always know where you are and what comes next.

1

Prepare

Pull your deposit together. Tidy your spending. Check your KiwiSaver. Understand what lenders actually look at before you apply.

2

Pre-approve

Get a written approval from the right lender so you can shop with confidence and act fast when the right home appears.

3

Purchase

Find the home. Make the offer. Get the deal across the line. Settle. Move in. We walk through every step together.

Why the order matters.

Most buyers jump straight to step three — scrolling Trade Me, falling in love with a listing, then scrambling to get finance. That's how offers fall over and good homes get lost to better-prepared buyers.

The Prepare stage takes a few weeks. The Pre-approve stage usually takes one to two weeks once your documents are ready. After that, you can move on a property the same week you find it — confident in what you can afford and what the lender will accept.



03 — PREPARE STAGE

Getting deposit-ready faster.

There's no magic formula. It comes down to four habits that compound. Start them now, even if buying still feels years away.

1 Know exactly what lenders look at.

Lenders check three things: your deposit size, your income reliability, and your spending patterns over the last few months. Buying lots of small things on Afterpay or running up the credit card eats into how much you can borrow. Tidy up the last three to six months of statements before you apply.

2 Treat your KiwiSaver as your deposit engine.

Most first home buyers use their KiwiSaver as the bulk of their deposit. Check your balance, confirm you've been contributing for the minimum qualifying period, and make sure you're in a fund that suits your timeframe to buy. The default fund isn't always the right one.

3 Don't rule out family help.

Gifted deposits and parental guarantees are more common than people think. Lenders have specific rules for how they treat them. There's a right and a wrong way to structure these — talk to an adviser before money moves.

4 Talk to an adviser before you think you're ready.

The most useful conversation is often six to twelve months before you plan to buy. We can look at what you'd qualify for today, what's holding you back, and exactly which numbers to move so you're approved when you need to be.

04 — THE JOURNEY

From first chat to collecting the keys.

Here's what the full process looks like when you work with me. Most clients move from the first conversation to moving in within three to six months, depending on the market and how prepared you are.

1 Free 30-minute consultation

We talk through where you are, what you want, and what's realistic. No cost. No pressure. If I'm not the right person to help, I'll tell you that too.

2 Gather your documents

Payslips, bank statements, KiwiSaver statement, ID. I send you a clear checklist so you know exactly what's needed and why.

3 Strategy and lender match

I compare your situation across the lender panel and pick the bank or non-bank lender most likely to approve, at the sharpest rate and best structure for your circumstances.

4 Pre-approval submitted

I prepare and submit your application, manage the back-and-forth with the lender, and chase down approval. You get a written pre-approval you can take to open homes and auctions.

5 Find your home and make an offer

Once you find the right property, I work with your solicitor and the lender to turn the pre-approval into a formal approval on that specific property. We move fast so you don't lose the deal.

6 Settlement and the keys

Funds settle. You collect the keys. I check in a year later to make sure your loan is still the right one for you — and every year after that.

05 — WHAT IT COSTS, WHAT HELPS

Costs and support explained.

There are real costs in buying a first home, and there's real support available. Here's what to know.

What it costs you.

Mortgage adviser fees

Nothing, in nearly every case. Lenders pay my commission when your loan settles. You get full advice, application support, and ongoing reviews at no cost to you.

Legal fees

You'll need a solicitor to handle the legal side of the purchase. Most charge a flat fee for a standard first home purchase. I can recommend solicitors who work well with first home buyers.

Building inspections and valuations

A pre-purchase building inspection is strongly recommended for nearly every home. Some lenders also require a registered valuation, depending on the property and your deposit. Costs vary by region and property type.

What support is available.

KiwiSaver first home withdrawal

If you meet the qualifying conditions, you can withdraw most of your KiwiSaver balance toward your first home deposit. This is the single biggest source of deposit funds for most first home buyers.

The First Home Loan (via Kāinga Ora)

A government-backed loan option that lets eligible first home buyers purchase with a lower deposit than standard bank lending allows. There are income caps and property price caps that change — I can check current eligibility for you in five minutes.

Gifted deposits and family support

Many lenders accept gifted deposits from family. Some accept parental guarantees. The right structure depends on the lender and your situation.

06 — REAL-LIFE EXAMPLES

Three Kiwi first home buyer journeys.

Names and details have been changed for privacy, but the situations are real. These are the kinds of clients I help every week.

RENTERS ON THE COAST**Emma & Tom**

Renting in Whangaparaōa, thought they were years off buying. We mapped their KiwiSaver, checked First Home Loan eligibility, and tidied up two small consumer loans that were hurting their borrowing power.

→ **Pre-approved in five weeks, in a home within four months.**

SELF-EMPLOYED**Hannah**

Self-employed graphic designer, declined by her main bank. The decline wasn't about her income — it was about how the bank read her financials. A second-tier lender treated her business income properly.

→ **Approved at a sharper rate than her bank had offered.**

FAMILY HELP**The Patel family**

Parents wanted to help with the deposit but weren't sure how. We structured a gifted deposit that satisfied the lender's rules and didn't complicate the parents' tax situation.

→ **First home settled. Parents' finances untouched.**

The pattern that connects them.

In every case, the client thought their situation was too hard, too complicated, or too far off. None of them were right. The real obstacle was almost always the same: **they didn't know which lender to ask, or how to ask in the right way.**

That's the part I solve.

07 — ADVISER VERSUS BANK

Why most first home buyers use an adviser.

Going direct to a bank	Working with a mortgage adviser
Access to one lender's products only	25+ lenders compared
Bank represents its own interests	Adviser works for you
One decline ends the process	Decline at one lender doesn't mean decline everywhere
You manage the paperwork and follow-up	Adviser manages it all
Advice limited to that bank's offering	Independent strategy and structure advice
Free (with restrictions)	Free to you — lender pays the adviser

08 — ARE YOU READY?

Five signs you're ready to start the conversation.

- You've started thinking seriously about buying within the next two years.**
 Even an early conversation gives you a roadmap. The earlier you start, the more options you have.
- You've been contributing to KiwiSaver and aren't sure how to use it.**
 Most first home buyers underuse their KiwiSaver. A quick review can unlock more deposit than you think.
- You've heard of the First Home Loan but don't know if you qualify.**
 Eligibility changes. The five-minute check is worth doing — it can change what you can buy.
- You've been told by a bank that you can't borrow as much as you'd hoped.**
 One bank's answer isn't every bank's answer. Different lenders read the same income very differently.
- You're self-employed, on a casual contract, or have other "non-standard" income.**
 This is where adviser-led applications most often beat going direct to a bank.

09 — FREQUENTLY ASKED QUESTIONS

Things first home buyers ask me before getting in touch.

How much deposit do I actually need?

It depends on the lender and your situation. Some first home buyers qualify with a smaller deposit through the First Home Loan or with a lender that has policy room above standard LVR limits. The right number for you depends on the property type, your income, and which lender we approach. A short call gives you a clear answer.

Can I use my KiwiSaver for the deposit?

In most cases yes, if you meet the qualifying conditions. We'll check your eligibility and confirm the amount you can withdraw before you start house hunting.

How long does pre-approval take?

It varies by lender and how complete your documents are. Some applications come back within days; others take a couple of weeks. We keep you in the loop the whole way.

Does using an adviser cost me anything?

No, in nearly every case. The lender pays the adviser when your loan settles. If for any reason a deal isn't paid by the lender, I'll tell you upfront before any work starts.

What if my bank already said no?

A decline at one bank is not a decline everywhere. Different lenders have different policies on income type, deposit source, credit history, and property type. Finding the right fit is the part I do.

Will applying affect my credit score?

A credit check has a small, temporary impact. We only run checks once we've agreed on the right lender to approach — we don't fire applications at multiple banks at once.

I'm self-employed. Can you still help?

Yes — this is one of the situations where having an adviser makes the biggest difference. Self-employed income can be presented very differently across lenders.

10 — NEXT STEPS

Ready when you are.

Three steps to get started. No cost. No pressure. Just a clear answer on what's possible.

1

Book a free
first home review

2

Get a clear answer
on what's possible

3

Decide your
next step

Talk to JJ.

Senior Mortgage Adviser · First home buyer specialist on Auckland's Hibiscus Coast

PHONE**027 336 3000****EMAIL****info@mortgageswithjj.co.nz****WEB****mortgageswithjj.co.nz****IMPORTANT DISCLOSURE**

JJ van der Westhuizen (FSP1000031) is a Senior Mortgage Adviser operating under the Financial Advice Provider licence of Mortgage Design NZ Limited (FSP752291).

This guide is general information only and does not constitute personalised financial advice. For advice tailored to your specific circumstances, please get in touch. A copy of our publicly available disclosure document is available on request, free of charge.